while doing time here. Even those who were being supposedly treated for drug abuse had free access to drugs. All along, in my earlier posting in Delhi, I had insisted that our work in Navjyoti was being jeopardized by the situation in the prison. But now I was at the helm of affairs and I decided to attack this problem with all I had. Now I had a chance to do what I had been requesting others to do in 1988.

I realized that the first step to be taken was to check the porosity of the barrier. My warders, some of whom were drug addicts themselves, were also actively engaged in peddling drugs in prison and making quite a packet. Security was at a discount. Because of this availability there was a lot of infighting among the prisoners and a staff– prisoner nexus had been formed. There was only one NGO-run centre for drug treatment but it was proving ineffective because all [its] work was being undone by the easy availability of the drugs. Mockery had been made of the system. I started work with the staff. We made checks on the drug smuggling into prison, trained the staff, sent a number of them for treatment at the Navjyoti clinics. I gave them a clear choice – either they go for treatment or I have them out of the force. Some volunteered, a few I had to axe.

We then shifted our efforts to the internal scene. The internal management system was made transparent. More centres for treatment were opened. Each jail has its own treatment centre where a new prisoner is taken directly on arrival. Immediately his physical condition is diagnosed and he is sent for treatment accordingly. We lay stress on homoeopathic treatment at the centres because at Navjyoti I had learnt that it was very effective, low cost and reduced dependence on allopathic drugs like proxyvon that itself created dependence. A number of NGOs came forward to offer help in treatment and counselling. So, at present we have Navjyoti working in Jail 1, internal work in Jail 2, Sahara, an NGO, is working in Jail 3 and Ashiana continues its good work in Jail 4. Another group, Aasra, supports the centre in Jail 4.

These efforts are showing results now. Many prisoners have now been able to become rehabilitated because they have been able to kick the habit that had been compelling them to recidivism. The new trend I noticed is that prisoners are coming to prison for treatment. By word of mouth of detoxified patients, new patients keep coming because now they know they can be detoxified because there is no accessibility to drugs in the jails any longer. Of course, attempts are still made by new inmates to smuggle in the stuff, but by and large supervision and surveillance are quite effective in checking them.

Out of the average of 300 prisoners coming in every day, 50 are drug addicts. The incidence of drug-related crimes being so high, it is most essential that this problem be dealt with effectively in the prisons. We still have far too little space in our treatment centres. We are, therefore, trying to institutionalize them. And, for that, we have sent a proposal to the Ministry of Health, Government of India, for establishing treatment centres like Navjyoti in the prisons to be run by the superintendent of the jail. We have requested for funds, in the form of grants from government, so that the superintendent can employ a team of homoeopaths, vocational trainers, yoga instructors, psychiatrists and social workers. It would involve an amount of Rs 10,000 to Rs 12,000 per superintendent per month to enable him to do so. These funds would go to the prisoners' welfare fund and be at the disposal of the respective superintendents to provide a holistic infrastructure to deal with the drug problem in prisons. The proposal is under active consideration of the government and is also being considered by the UN Drug Control Programme. NGOs have their own limitations and the institutionalizing of the programme would bring in much greater control in functioning by the jail staff itself. One large prison is on the verge of being declared a demonstration project to be steered by Dr Harinder Sethi of Aasra (an